

Character reference photo generation

Cost control plan — prepared for Wigly · August 9, 2026

Summary

The “Describe them and generate one” button on the character page calls OpenAI or fal.ai directly to generate a reference photo. It was never gated by a plan or credit check, so any signed-up account — paying or not — could generate unlimited photos for free, billed to the business. Free accounts are already capped (2 lifetime, shipped). This plan proposes closing the same gap for paying customers, without touching the “unlimited character profiles” promise on the pricing page.

What happened

A new signup (plan: none) generated an AI reference photo for a character with zero allowance — confirmed against the account directly: no active plan, no bonus credits, and zero rows in the generation history table, meaning they never touched the metered video/image composer. The character page's photo generator was a separate code path that was simply never wired to the same allowance check.

Status	What it covers
Fixed (shipped)	Free accounts (plan = none) capped at 2 lifetime AI-generated reference photos. Uploading your own photo was always free and still is, no cap.
Still open	Every paying plan — Starter, Growth, Studio, Elite — has no cap and no cooldown on this same button. A script could run it continuously at no cost to the user.

What a reference photo actually costs

The default model, GPT Image 2, bills OpenAI's published token rate of \$30 per million output tokens for a 1024×1024 image. The app doesn't force a quality level, so OpenAI picks automatically — in practice this lands low, medium, or high depending on the prompt:

Quality	Output tokens	Cost per photo
Low	272	\$0.008
Medium (typical)	1,056	\$0.032
High	4,160	\$0.125

Source: OpenAI's published API pricing and documented per-image token counts for gpt-image-2 at 1024×1024, as of August 2026.

For comparison, the video product already prices 1 plan credit at roughly \$0.28 of real provider cost, and sells it for \$1.66–\$2.00 depending on plan — a healthy 6–7x markup. A reference photo at typical (medium) quality costs about a ninth of that — charging a full credit for it would be overpriced relative to what it is; leaving it free, as today, is what let a \$0 account generate for free.

Recommendation

Give every paid plan a flat 15 AI-generated reference photos per month, tracked separately from the video/image credit pool, resetting each billing cycle. Same number on all four tiers — the true cost is trivial regardless of plan, so there's no reason to scale it. Uploading a photo remains free and unlimited, and the number of characters an account can create remains unlimited — only the AI-generation button is metered.

15/month comfortably covers normal use — a handful of characters with a few tries each to get the face right — while putting a hard, predictable ceiling under any account that isn't a real person using the product normally.

Projected cost impact by plan

Monthly cost if every one of the 15 photos happened to land at typical (medium) quality, versus the worst case where all 15 land at high quality:

Plan	Price/mo	Allowance	Typical cost	% of price	Worst case	% of price
Starter	\$19	15/mo	\$0.45	2.4%	\$1.88	9.9%
Growth	\$79	15/mo	\$0.45	0.6%	\$1.88	2.4%
Studio	\$299	15/mo	\$0.45	0.2%	\$1.88	0.6%
Elite	\$499	15/mo	\$0.45	0.1%	\$1.88	0.4%

Even in the worst case, this stays well under the margin already built into the plan — on Starter it's under 10 cents on the dollar of a single month's subscription, and it drops fast on every tier above it.

What doesn't change

- “Unlimited character profiles” stays true on all four plans — there's no limit on how many characters an account can create.
- Uploading your own reference photo stays free and unlimited — it costs nothing to serve.
- Free (plan = none) accounts keep the 2-lifetime cap already shipped — unaffected by this plan.
- Admin accounts stay exempt, same as every other usage gate in the product.

How this would be built

A new monthly counter on the account, separate from the existing video/image credit balance — the same pattern already used for the free-tier cap, except this one resets automatically at the start of each billing cycle instead of being a one-time lifetime limit. Once an account uses its 15 for the month, the button shows a plain message and offers to upload a photo instead, same as the free-tier version does today. No pricing page changes needed unless you want to publicize the number.

Decision needed

Confirm the number (15/month) and whether it should be the same across all four plans, or scaled up on the higher tiers as a perk. Once confirmed, this is a small, low-risk change to build and verify.

Prepared from a direct review of the codebase and OpenAI's published API pricing. All dollar figures are estimates based on list pricing, not an invoice.